Magyar rule. Further south-east, Serbs and Bulgarians too had their medieval states. For the south-eastern Slavs, the Greeks and some other nations in this part of Europe, however, the end of political autonomy came with the beginning of the Ottoman conquest of European territory in the fourteenth century. This also shook the Hungarian kingdom and the lands of the Moldavians and the Wallachians, the ancestors of Romanians. The period of Ottoman rule and its key significance for this part of Eastern Europe will be looked at closely in a separate chapter. For now, it is important to realise that the centuries of Ottoman rule (which, despite occasional uprisings, were largely peaceful times) somehow froze the history of south-eastern Europe until the nineteenth century when the Ottoman Empire began to collapse and Russia also started to exercise a stronger influence in the region.

The crumbling Ottoman Empire made possible the Russian advance towards the Black Sea and the Mediterranean. This went hand-in-hand with the rise of several, mostly (but not solely) Slavic and Orthodox Christian nations in parts of the falling Ottoman Empire. Thus the new Eastern question – who was to get the spoils from the final wars against the dying Ottoman Empire? – enabled Russia to gain a stronger influence in Eastern Europe. This was made easier by the common Slavic and religious (Orthodox Christian) roots of the Russians and of some of the liberated Slavs. Shared Slavic origins continued to appeal even to the Catholic Slavs of the West, like the Czechs and the Slovenians, who, at least at certain points in their history, saw in Russia a beacon of Slavic power and might, and an inspiration against the rising German nationalism of the late nineteenth century, even when there was no physical contact with the Russians. The so-called Pan-Slavic campaign, a nineteenth-century patriotic movement emphasising the unity of all Slavs, drew on the even older sources of the two preachers, the brothers Constantine and Methodius. Although the two were Greeks and not Slavs, they continued to be known as the Apostles of the Slavs even in Catholic countries. Their feast according to the Catholic calendar is still a public holiday in the Czech Republic, which is otherwise rather reserved on the topic of shared Slavic roots and, in any event, one of the most secularised societies in Europe.

The Pan-Slavic movement remained more or less on the level of an idea, with little practical consequences, but, even in the twentieth century,